05

PART 5 OF 9

The Kingdom of Israel

1SAM9–2KGS1;1CHR10–2CHR10

From the first king in the hills of Benjamin to the prophet on Mount Carmel.



From Shepherds' Hills to Royal Cities

Imagine a land where judges ruled not long ago and every tribe guarded its own valley. Around 1000 BC this changes: a king appears. Saul rules from Gibeah, a small town on a mountain ridge, David captures Jerusalem, and Solomon turns it into a capital with a palace and a temple. The books of Samuel, Kings, and Chronicles tell of this turning point, in which politics, faith, and geography are tightly intertwined. When reading these books, it pays to keep glancing at the map, because many of the tensions come from distance and terrain.

The map of this part is surprisingly compact. It is about 30 km from Jerusalem to Hebron, a little over 15 km to Bethel, and about 150 km in a straight line to the Sea of Galilee. The central hills offered shelter and water, the Jezreel Valley opened the way to the coast and Damascus, and the coastal route linked Egypt with Mesopotamia. Whoever controlled Megiddo, Hazor, and Gezer watched the merchants carrying goods from one empire to another. That is why, for every chapter of this part, it matters not only what happened, but also where and under what conditions.

The story does not end with the golden age. After Solomon's death, around 931 BC, the kingdom splits into two states: Judah with Jerusalem in the south and Israel with its capital in Samaria in the north. Against this background prophets appear, among them Elijah, who stands on Mount Carmel before King Ahab. The twelve places in this part lead you from Gibeah to the Valley of

Jezreel; some of them are artistic reconstructions based on excavations. Notice how the mood of the story changes from place to place: from cramped mountain villages to wide valleys and the coast.

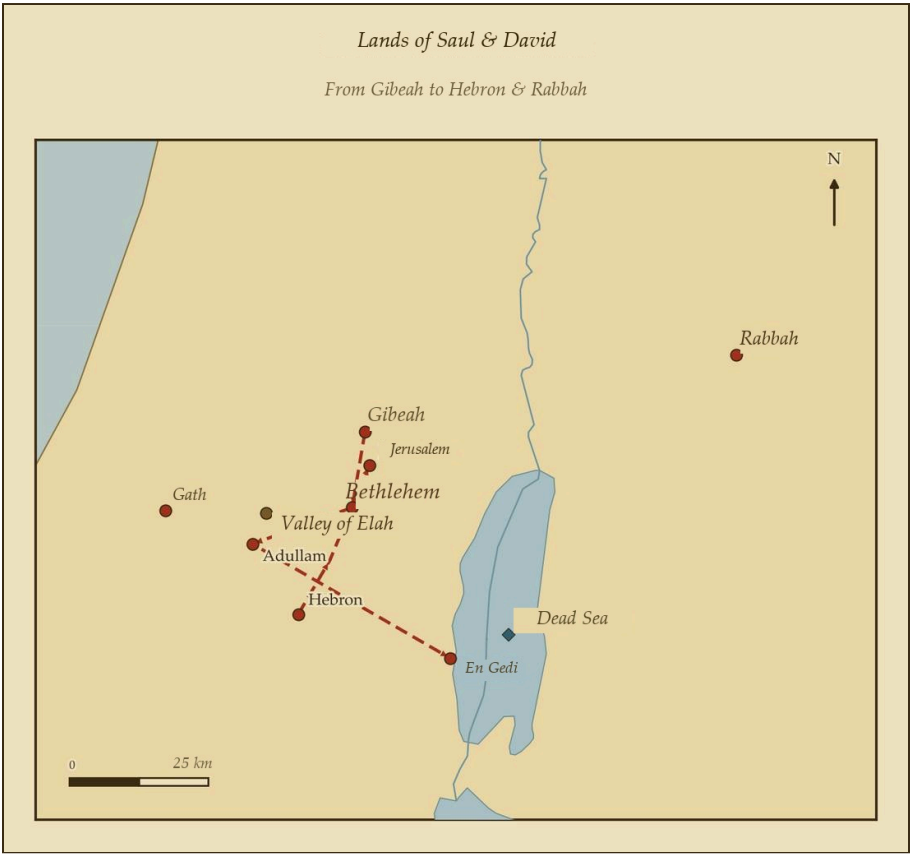
INDEX OF PLACES AND SCENES

01	Gibeah of Saul	*1 Sam 10; 1 Sam 13–15; 1 Sam 22*
02	Valley of Elah	*1 Sam 17*
03	Hebron	*2 Sam 2–5; Gen 23*
04	City of David in Jerusalem	*2 Sam 5–6; 1 Chr 11*
05	Rabbah of the Ammonites	*2 Sam 10–12*
06	Solomon's Temple	*1 Kgs 5–8; 2 Chr 2–7*
07	Megiddo	*1 Kgs 9:15; 1 Kgs 4:12; 2 Kgs 23:29*
08	Hazor and Gezer	*1 Kgs 9:15–17; Josh 11:10*
09	Dan and Bethel	*1 Kgs 12:25–33*
10	Samaria	*1 Kgs 16:23–28; 1 Kgs 20; 2 Kgs 6–7*
11	Mount Carmel	*1 Kgs 18*
12	Jezreel	*1 Kgs 21; 2 Kgs 9–10*

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

The maps show routes and the locations of places; the illustrations are artistic reconstructions based on archaeological knowledge, not photographs. Distances and dimensions are approximate.

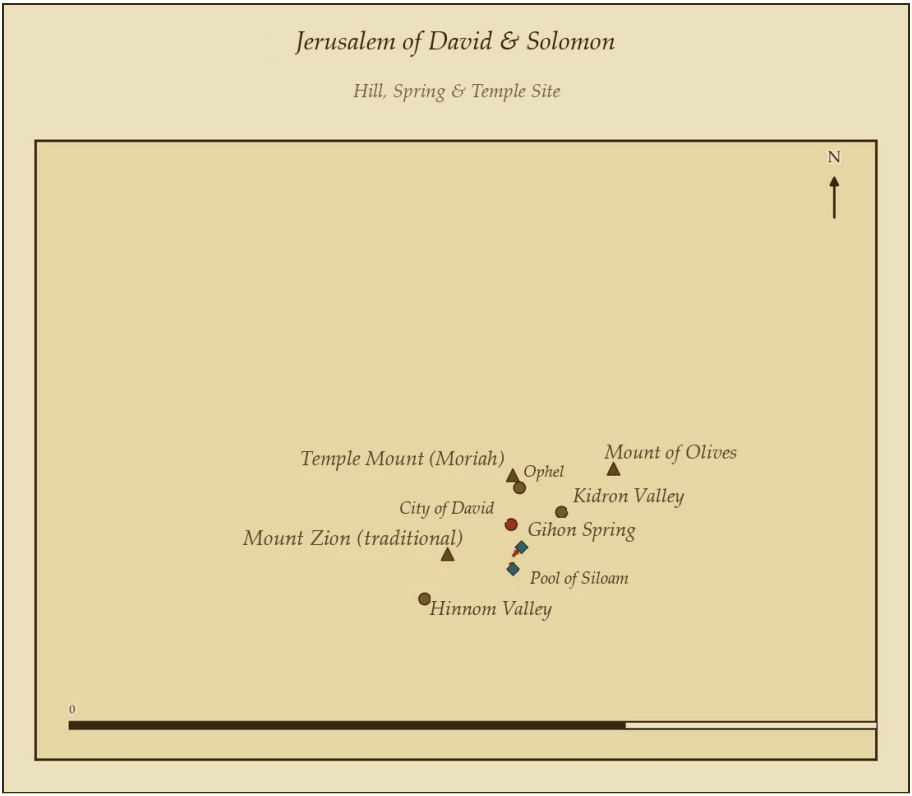
MAP 5.1



The first line shows David's flight from Saul, and the second his move from Hebron to Jerusalem. The hills of Judah and Benjamin lie in the middle, the Philistines to the west, the Ammonites to the east.

The map shows how small the territory of the first kings was: it is only about 35 km from Gibeah to Hebron. Saul held the north of the hills, David started from the south, and Jerusalem lay between them. The Philistines pressed in from the west through the valleys, and the Ammonites from the highlands of Transjordan. This makes it easier to understand why David sought refuge in the wilderness by the Dead Sea, and why a capital on the border between tribes gave him an advantage.

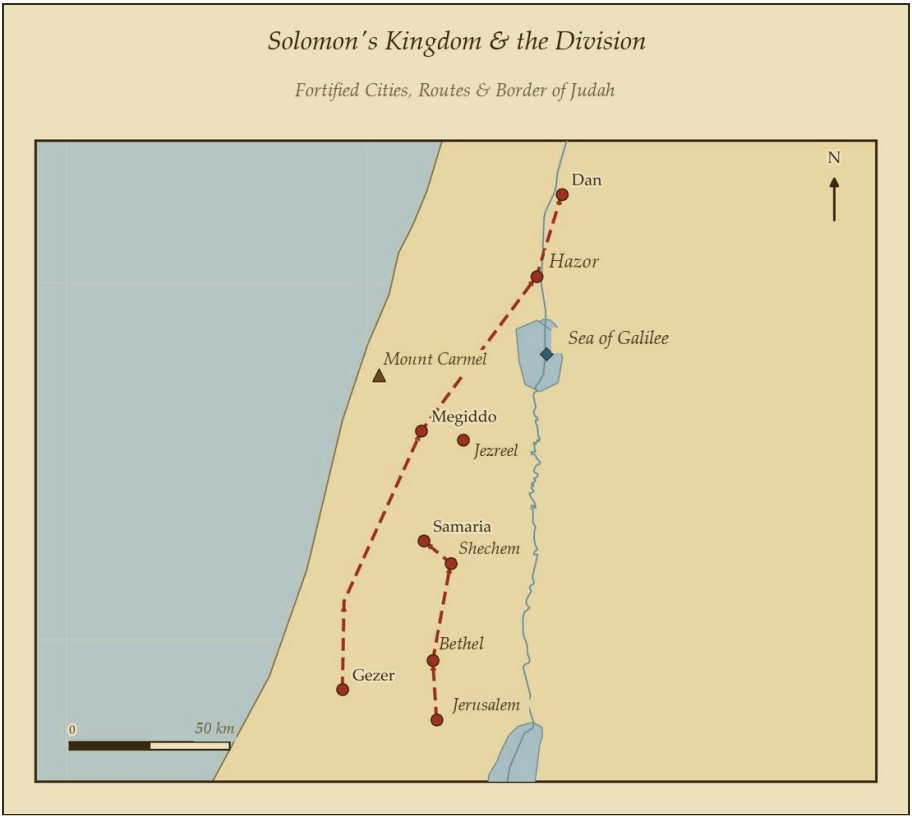
MAP 5.2



The map shows a very small area. The narrow hill of the City of David lies above the Gihon Spring, and to the north rises the Temple Mount. The line shows the later water tunnel built under Hezekiah (2 Kgs 20:20).

David's capital occupied a small ridge surrounded by the Kidron and Hinnom valleys. The Gihon Spring supplied water but lay outside the walls, so later generations built tunnels to conceal it. Solomon moved the center of power north, to the temple hill, and joined it to the old city. The map shows how compact Jerusalem was: walking from one end to the other took a few minutes.

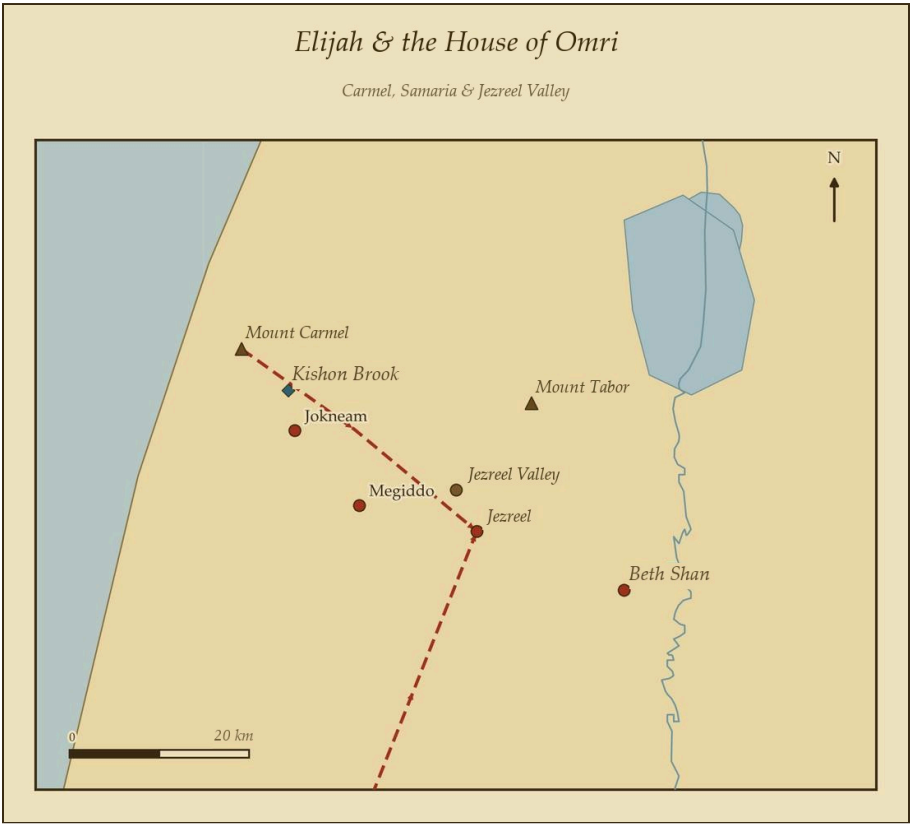
MAP 5.3



The first line shows the ancient coastal route along which Solomon fortified cities. The second runs through the hills from Jerusalem by way of Bethel and Shechem to Samaria. The dividing border ran near Bethel.

Solomon strung his fortresses along the Via Maris like beads on a string: Gezer, Megiddo, Hazor. After his death, around 931 BC, the land divided along the border of Benjamin. Judah kept Jerusalem and the hills of the south, while Israel received the fertile north, with its valleys and routes. Bethel and Dan became sanctuaries and Samaria the capital. The map shows why the north was richer and the south harder to conquer.

MAP 5.4



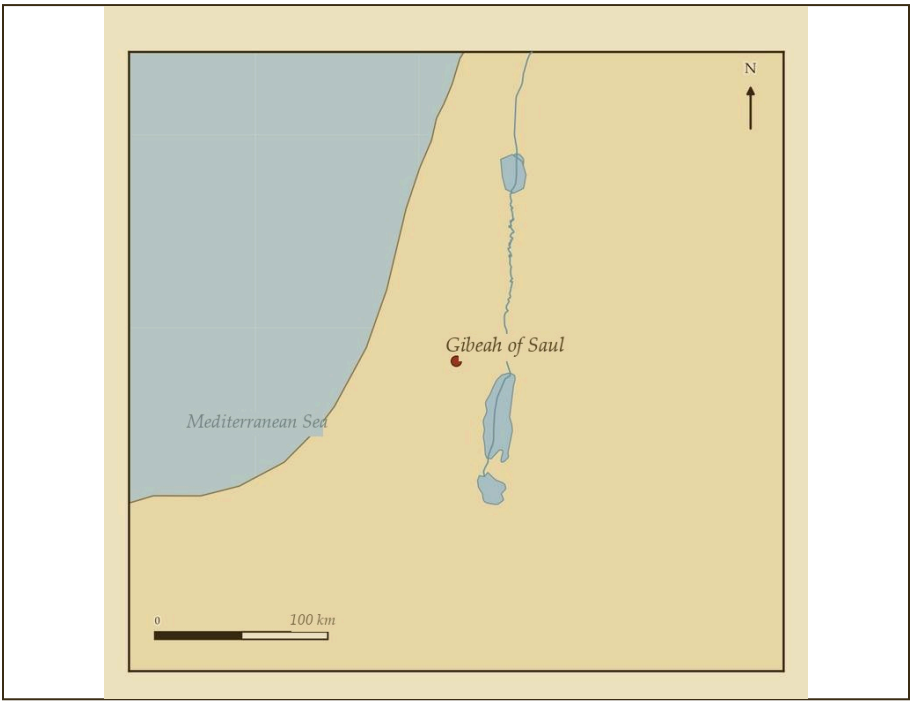
The map shows the north of the kingdom of Israel. The first line shows the road from Carmel to Jezreel that, according to the text, Ahab traveled while the prophet ran ahead of his chariot. The second links the capital with the summer residence.

The dynasty of Omri ruled from Samaria but loved Jezreel, where the climate was milder and the soil fertile. Carmel, by the sea, separated the valley from the coast, and it was there that the struggle took place over whom the people would trust with their faith. The distance from Carmel to Jezreel is about 30 km, which explains the account of the prophet running ahead of the chariot. The map shows that the events of Elijah's life unfolded in an area no bigger than a single modern municipality.

01 Gibeah of Saul

1 SAM 10; 1 SAM 13–15; 1 SAM 22

The modest seat of Israel's first king on the hill of Benjamin.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Tradition points to Tell el-Ful, a flat-topped mound above present-day Jerusalem. The artistic reconstruction shows a small fortress with a thick wall of rough stones, a corner tower, and a few mud-brick houses. Around it stretch terraces of barley, olive trees, and flocks of sheep. The dust of the mountain road hangs over everything, and in the distance the ridges of Judah can be seen. Over it all one senses a stark simplicity: no columns, no marble, only sturdiness and the smoke of cooking fires.

5.1 · GIBEAH OF SAUL · 1 SAM 10; 1 SAM 13–15; 1 SAM 22

The Book of Samuel tells how Saul, son of Kish of the tribe of Benjamin, was anointed by the prophet Samuel and proclaimed king. Yet he did not settle in a palace: he returned to Gibeah, where he governed among shepherds and farmers. His court was modest, and his power rested on constant readiness for war. When the Philistines threatened the land, he gathered volunteers from around Gibeah and Michmash. Over time his relations with Samuel and with the young David soured, which the biblical authors present as the drama of a rejected ruler. For the reader, what matters is that the Book of Samuel does not hide the tensions: the king could be unsure and fearful, and his decisions stirred conflict with the prophet.

Gibeah lay on a mountain ridge about 5 km north of what would become Jerusalem, beside the road running along the central hills from south to north. This hill of Benjamin was an observation point: from here one could see Jerusalem, the valleys descending toward the Jordan, and the movements of armies coming from the west. Narrow passes, such as nearby Michmash, allowed a small army to hold back a far larger enemy. This explains why the first king chose a defensible place rather than a trading center. A place like this explains well the style of the first government: a small capital, closeness to the fields, and constant vigilance against a threat that could come from any side.

FACTS

Hill elevation approx. 840 m above sea level; distance to Jerusalem approx. 5 km.

02 Valley of Elah

1SAM17

The battlefield of David and Goliath between Socoh and Azekah.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a wide valley with a shallow, stony brook in the middle. On one slope stands the Philistine camp with tents and bronze shields, on the other a plainer Israelite encampment among olive groves. Between them, far off, two tiny figures face each other. The air is dry, the light sharp, and spreading terebinth trees grow over the valley. The rest of the picture is the stillness before the clash: the clink of metal, the snorting of animals, and the short shouts of commanders carry far.

5.2 · VALLEY OF ELAH · 1 SAM 17

According to the Book of Samuel, the Philistines gathered their forces at Socoh in Judah, and Saul drew up the Israelites on the other side of the Valley of Elah. For many days the giant Goliath came out of the enemy camp, challenging the Israelites to fight. David, who had brought food to his brothers, could no longer bear to watch this humiliation. He rejected Saul's armor and took a staff, a sling, and a few smooth stones from the brook. He defeated his opponent, and the Philistines fled toward Gath and Ekron, pursued by the Israelites. The story also has a symbolic dimension, but its setting is very concrete: two armies, one valley, and a local brook that supplied the stones.

The Valley of Elah, today Wadi es-Sant, is a natural boundary between the Shephelah and the hills of Judah. It runs from east to west and opens the way for the Philistines from the coastal plain toward Bethlehem and Hebron. The slopes are gentle, the valley floor wide and strewn with stones, which explains the motif of the sling. For the Israelites, control of this valley meant the defense of the hills. Archaeologists are studying a fortified city from David's time nearby, Khirbet Qeiyafa, though its connection to the duel itself remains a matter of debate. Geography thus hints at why this valley kept returning in history: whoever stood on the hill saw the enemy's movements, and whoever went down to the bottom exposed himself to fire.

FACTS

From Khirbet Qeiyafa to Jerusalem approx. 30 km; the valley is approx. 2–3 km wide.


N
Valley of Elah
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

03 Hebron

2 SAM 2–5; GEN 23

David's first capital as king of Judah.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a town on a hillside, with closely packed stone houses, narrow lanes, and a square by the gate where the elders gathered. Around it are cascading terraces of grapevines, olive groves, and herds of goats. The backdrop is the pale limestone hills of Judah, and the air is cooler than in the desert to the east. In the evening smoke rises from the chimneys, and from below come the voices of shepherds calling their flocks into the pens.

5.3 · HEBRON · 2 SAM 2–5; GEN 23

After Saul's death, David asks God where he should go and sets out for Hebron. The elders of Judah anoint him here as king of their tribe, while the north remains with the house of Saul. Years of civil war follow, until the killing of the commander Abner and of King Ish-bosheth. Then the representatives of the tribes come to Hebron and recognize David as ruler of all the Israelites. The Book of Samuel says that he reigned in Hebron for about seven and a half years and later moved to Jerusalem. Hebron remains important afterward too: it is here that Absalom will declare his rebellion against his father, and the city will long keep its significance for the tribe of Judah.

Hebron lies about 30 km south of Jerusalem, at an elevation of about 930 m above sea level, the highest of all the major cities of Judah. The surrounding area is fertile: vineyards, olive groves, and pastures gave the town wealth, and the nearby Cave of Machpelah is associated with the tombs of the patriarchs. Roads led from Hebron to Beersheba and the Negev and to the coast. For David, who came from the tribe of Judah, it was a natural base, but too far from the northern tribes to rule the whole land. The choice of place shows the first phase of David's reign, when he relied on his own tribe and friends from the south, before he built a state covering the entire land.

FACTS

Distance to Jerusalem approx. 30 km; elevation approx. 930 m above sea level.

04 City of David in Jerusalem

2 SAM 5–6; 1 CHR 11

The Jebusite stronghold that became the capital of all Israel.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

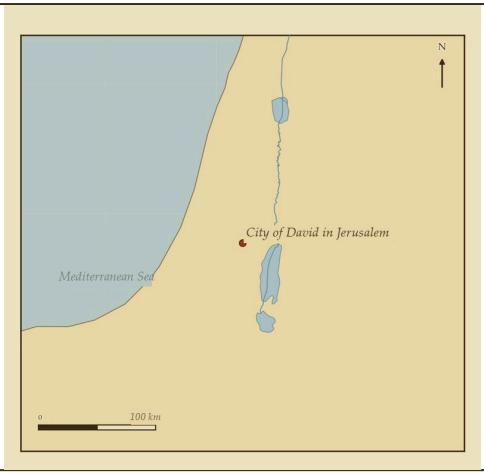
The artistic reconstruction shows a tightly built ridge, descending in terraces toward the Kidron Valley. Stone houses rise one above another, and above them stands a fortified citadel. On the east side a path leads to the Gihon Spring, where women fill their jars. In the background, to the north, lies a still-empty plateau on which the temple was built later. The whole gives the impression of a dense settlement stretched along the ridge, full of the smells of smoke, herbs, and sun-warmed stone.

After being crowned over all Israel, David turns against Jerusalem, which the Jebusites still held. The inhabitants felt safe behind their walls, but David's troops entered the city through the so-called water shaft; the Hebrew text uses a rare word here, whose meaning scholars debate. David occupies the stronghold, builds walls around it, and calls it the City of David. Then he brings the Ark of the Covenant here with great joy, dancing before it. Jerusalem becomes the political and religious capital. The transfer of the Ark joins power and worship in this story: the king not only captures a city but makes it the place toward which the whole people are heading.

The choice was deliberate. Jerusalem lies on the border of Judah and Benjamin, so it favored neither side. The narrow hill between the Kidron and Tyropoeon valleys was easy to defend, and the Gihon Spring at its foot gave a constant water supply. The city stood away from the main trade routes, which protected it from threats but required access roads. David gained a capital that was neutral between the tribes and militarily secure. Note the order: first the fortress and walls, then the sanctuary, and only years later the temple, which shows the gradual maturing of the capital.

FACTS

Area of the ancient city approx. 5 hectares; the Gihon Spring approx. 100 m from the top of the hill.


N
City of David in Jerusalem
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

05 Rabbah of the Ammonites

2 SAM 10–12

The city besieged by Joab, where David's drama unfolded.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a fortified hill above a dry valley, with a row of houses clinging to the slope and a wide gate. At the foot, along a brook, stand the tents of the besiegers, and helmets gleam on the walls among the defenders. The surroundings are open, barren, covered with low shrubs and limestone boulders. The air is full of dust and the sound of horn signals, and in the distance Ammonite shepherds' flocks graze.

When the king of the Ammonites insulted David's envoys, war broke out. Joab, the commander of the army, besieged Rabbah, the Ammonite capital, while David remained in Jerusalem. There the events with Bathsheba and Uriah the Hittite took place, whom the king sent to the front line so that he would die. The prophet Nathan tells a parable and accuses the king. David admits his guilt. Meanwhile Joab captures part of the city, the so-called city of waters, and summons the king to take the rest himself. These scenes set two worlds side by side: the battlefield, where soldiers carry out orders, and the palace, where the ruler forgets responsibility for his own deeds.

Rabbah lay on the hills of present-day Amman, across the Jordan, about 65 km in a straight line from Jerusalem. The road led down to the Jordan Valley and then steeply up the slopes of Transjordan, which meant two to three days' march for an army. By the springs of the Jabbok River the city had a steady water supply, so a siege was long. This distance explains why the king could stay in the capital while the war was fought far from his sight. The biblical authors do not hide the shadow over the most famous king, and the geographic description helps us grasp how great a distance separated decisions from their consequences.

FACTS

Distance to Jerusalem approx. 65 km in a straight line; elevation approx. 800–850 m above sea level.

06 Solomon's Temple

1 KGS 5–8; 2 CHR 2–7

The first temple on Mount Moriah, built in about seven years.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

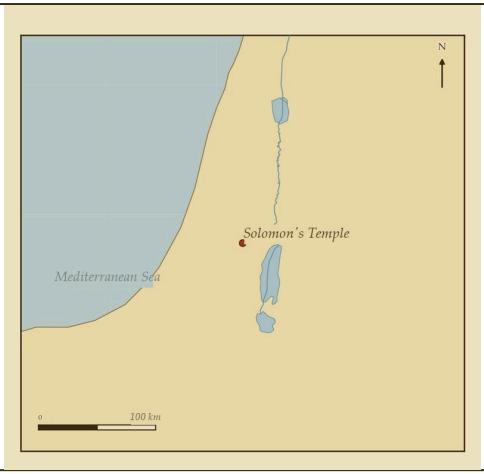
The artistic reconstruction shows a rectangular building of pale stone, with two freestanding pillars at the entrance and low chambers on the sides. Before it lies a courtyard with a great altar and a bronze basin on the backs of bull figures. The interior remains unseen, shielded by cedar doors. Workers in the background are laying the last blocks of the wall. The golden elements inside reflect the light of lamps, and the scent of cedar and incense fills the whole courtyard.

The Book of Kings tells how Solomon made an agreement with Hiram, king of Tyre, who supplied cedar and cypress timber and craftsmen. The work lasted about seven years. The temple consisted of a porch, a main hall, and the most holy place, where the Ark of the Covenant stood. The interior was covered with wood and gold and adorned with carved cherubim, palm trees, and flowers. At the dedication Solomon prayed over the people, asking that God hear those who turn toward this place. The account in Chronicles stresses David's preparations: he gathered materials and plans, though he himself was not permitted to build the temple.

The building stood north of the old city, on the hill that tradition links with Mount Moriah. Solomon had to widen the plateau by raising retaining walls around it. The stone was quarried nearby, and the timber was floated from Lebanon by sea to Joppa and then hauled to the hills of Judah, a climb of about 60 km. The location itself set the temple apart: it stood higher than the palaces and the city and was visible from every side. Archaeology has not found the building itself, because later temples stood on its site, so every picture is a reconstruction based on the text and on comparison with similar buildings of the region.

FACTS

Dimensions of the main hall according to the text: 60 × 20 × 30 cubits, or about 27 × 9 × 13.5 m.


N
Solomon's Temple
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

07 Megiddo

1 KGS 9:15; 1 KGS 4:12; 2 KGS 23:29

A fortified crossroads at the entrance to the Jezreel Valley.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a tall, oval mound above a green plain, surrounded by stone walls and a gate with several guard chambers. Inside are barracks and large structures that scholars interpret as stables or storehouses. On the road at the foot, a caravan of donkeys and camels passes, and in the distance the ridge of Carmel gleams. Roads run at the foot of the wall like broad ribbons, and among the fields lie small villages dependent on the city.

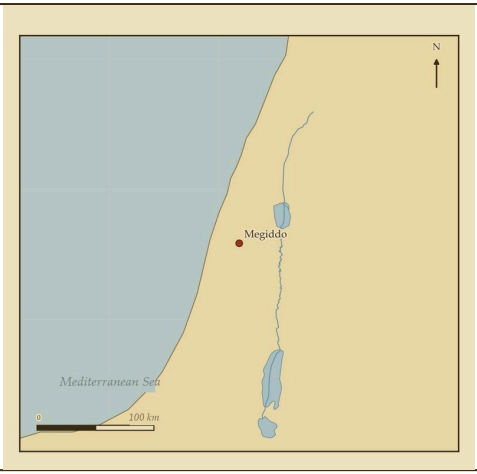
5.7 · MEGIDDO · 1 KGS 9:15; 1 KGS 4:12; 2 KGS 23:29

The Book of Kings lists Megiddo among the cities that Solomon built up, together with Hazor and Gezer. This was meant to secure control of the most important trade artery. Alongside barracks and storehouses, gates were erected, and scholarly tradition describes a multi-chambered gate from Solomon's time, though its dating is debated. Later, near the city, King Josiah was killed in a clash with Pharaoh Necho (2 Kgs 23). That is why Megiddo went down in history as a place of battles. From a biblical perspective, fortifications served not only war: they allowed tolls to be collected from caravans, secured supplies, and strengthened the ruler's prestige before his neighbors.

Tel Megiddo rises on the edge of the Jezreel Valley, at a narrow pass through the Carmel hills, about 30 km from the coast. Through this pass ran the coastal route, the Via Maris, linking Egypt with Syria and onward to Mesopotamia. Whoever held this pass could levy tolls and stop armies. Archaeological discoveries confirm that the city existed continuously for millennia, with traces of destruction and rebuilding appearing layer upon layer. The name Har-Magedon in the Book of Revelation, written in its Greek form, refers to this hill, though its exact understanding remains a subject of scholarly study.

FACTS

Height of the mound approx. 60 m above its surroundings; approx. 30 distinct settlement layers.


N
Megiddo
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

08 Hazor and Gezer

1 KGS 9:15–17; JOSH 11:10

The largest city of Canaan and its counterpart in the west.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a flat mound above a valley, with a massive wall surrounding the upper city. Against the backdrop of the dark hills of Galilee stands a gate with towers, and beyond it wide wheat fields. Before the gate merchants bustle with heavy sacks, soldiers guard the entrance, and smoke rises from chimneys. As the sun sets, the walls turn a rusty color, and the guards light torches on the towers.

The text of the First Book of Kings joins three cities: Hazor, Megiddo, and Gezer. Solomon rebuilt all of them as part of a fortification program. Gezer, according to the narrative, was captured by Pharaoh, who burned the city and gave it to his daughter as a dowry. Solomon rebuilt it. These three points formed a defensive and tax system and, at the same time, showed that the kingdom had formed ties with neighboring powers, including Egypt. It is worth remembering that this is an overall picture: the Bible describes here the king's building plan, and archaeologists compare it with the layers of walls and gates uncovered in the three cities.

Hazor lay in the north, above the Huleh Valley, about 15 km north of the Sea of Galilee. It was a great hub where roads from Damascus, Phoenicia, and Egypt met. The upper city covered under 10 hectares, but the lower, according to research, about 70 hectares, making it the largest center of Canaan. Gezer, by contrast, guarded the western road to Jerusalem, running through the Shephelah. Both cities lay on the edges of the kingdom, where the question of borders was decided. Gezer also shows relations with Egypt: marriage to the Pharaoh's daughter was regarded as an honor, and her dowry was a real political gesture toward the young kingdom.

FACTS

Lower city of Hazor approx. 70 hectares; distance to Dan approx. 20 km.

09 Dan and Bethel

1 KGS 12:25–33

Jeroboam's two sanctuaries at the ends of the northern kingdom.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a sanctuary on a rise by springs, with a raised worship platform and an altar of hewn stone. Tall trees grow around it and water murmurs, which sets Dan apart from the dry lands of the south. Priests and pilgrims in plain robes approach up the steps, and in the background the snowy cap of Mount Hermon can be seen. Even without sculptures and ornaments the place looks solemn, and the sound of the springs fills the whole area.

After Solomon's death, his son Rehoboam rejected the request for lighter taxes, and the northern tribes chose Jeroboam as king. He feared that pilgrimages to Jerusalem would lead the people to return to the rule of Judah. So he appointed two centers of worship, Bethel on the southern border and Dan on the northern, and set up golden calves in them. The author of the Book of Kings regards this step as a sin that weighed on the kings of Israel for centuries. The division of the kingdom was not only a matter of politics. It was tied to the memory of ancient sanctuaries and to the question of where the people should offer sacrifices and keep the feasts.

The choice of places made geographic sense. Bethel lies about 17 km north of Jerusalem, on the main road of the hills, and had been a holy place since the time of the patriarchs. Dan lies far in the north, by the sources of the Jordan, about 150 km from Jerusalem. The two sanctuaries covered the whole land and gave pilgrims a substitute for Jerusalem's worship closer to home. Politically it was a shrewd move, showing how closely religion and borders are bound together. The prophets of later centuries would return to these two places as an example of true worship mixed with political calculation, and the Books of Kings repeat this judgment many times.

FACTS

Dan: approx. 150 km in a straight line from Jerusalem; Bethel: approx. 17 km.

10 Samaria

1 KGS 16:23–28; 1 KGS 20; 2 KGS 6–7

The capital of the northern kingdom, founded by Omri.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a round hill surrounded by a double wall of well-dressed blocks. At the top stands a palace with a courtyard, and a paved road leads up to it from the fields. Below stretch barley fields and vineyards, and in the background the gentle hills of Samaria. The atmosphere is more lavish than in Gibeah. From the walls one sees the wide countryside, and in the valley farmers work among terraces and olive groves.

The Book of Kings says that Omri bought the hill from Shemer for two talents of silver and built a city on it, which he named Samaria. His son Ahab married Jezebel, daughter of the king of Sidon, and built a temple of Baal in the capital. The city was besieged several times by the Arameans. The stories of Elisha and the famine in Samaria show how strongly harsh conditions affected the lives of its inhabitants. In the end Samaria fell in 722 BC to Assyria. Samaria later gave its name to the whole region and its people, and its role in the New Testament, where it appears in the encounters of Jesus and the apostles, reaches many centuries further.

The choice of the hill was deliberate. It lies in the central hills, about 10 km northwest of Shechem, at an elevation of about 430 m above sea level, with a flat, wide valley all around. The city stood on its own rise, free of competition from old tribal centers, yet close to the road to the coast and the Jezreel Valley. Archaeologists have uncovered monumental walls and ivory that decorated furniture, which agrees with the mention of the house of ivory (1 Kgs 22:39). The biblical text describes here not only politics but also a conflict of values: kings sought alliances with their neighbors, while prophets demanded faithfulness to the covenant.

FACTS

Hill elevation approx. 430 m above sea level; purchase price according to the text: 2 talents of silver.


N
Samaria
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

11 Mount Carmel

1 KGS 18

The site of Elijah's contest with the prophets of Baal.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a rocky summit covered with oaks, shrubs, and wild herbs. On a flat spot stands an altar of twelve stones, and a crowd of villagers and soldiers gathers around it. Far behind them a strip of sea shimmers, and on the horizon the first small cloud appears. The wind carries the scent of resin and the moisture off the sea, and the shadows of clouds drift across the slopes.

After three years of drought, Elijah summons King Ahab to gather the people and the prophets of Baal on Mount Carmel. The question is to be settled here: which God is true. The prophets of Baal cry out from morning until noon, but no one answers. Elijah rebuilds the altar, arranges the offering, and pours water over it. Only then does he pray, and fire falls from heaven. The people declare their faith in the God of Israel. Then the prophet climbs up and prays for rain, while his servant watches for a cloud over the sea. The story also contains a moment of silence: after the roar and the fire, the prophet is weary and discouraged, and the story leads him on into the desert and as far as Mount Horeb (1 Kgs 19).

Carmel is a limestone ridge about 25 km long, running from the coast toward the Jezreel Valley. Its peaks reach about 550 m above sea level. From the west comes moist air off the sea, which even in a drought brings dew and lush vegetation here, which is why Carmel was associated with fertility. From the upper parts one can see both the Mediterranean Sea and the Kishon Valley, where the sentence was later carried out. This explains why this very place was chosen. It is one of the most famous scenes of the Old Testament, in which geography, weather, and faith form one coherent story about trust.

FACTS

Ridge about 25 km long; highest point approx. 550 m above sea level.


N
Mount Carmel
Mediterranean Sea
0
50 km

12 Jezreel

1 KGS 21; 2 KGS 9–10

Ahab's summer residence and Naboth's vineyard.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a fortified palace on a small rise, with a watchtower taller than the walls. At its feet stretch vineyards and wheat fields, and beyond them a wide green valley as far as the mountains of Gilboa. The road runs straight across the plain, allowing riders approaching to be spotted from afar. In the evening the valley fills with golden light, and the roads vanish in the mist rising over the fields.

5.12 · JEZREEL · 1 KGS 21; 2 KGS 9–10

In Jezreel Ahab had a palace next to Naboth's vineyard. When the king wanted to acquire it, Naboth refused, appealing to the inheritance of his ancestors. Jezebel forged documents, and Naboth was put to death. Elijah announced the punishment to Ahab. Years later the prophecy was fulfilled: Jehu, anointed king, rode into Jezreel and killed Joram, and Jezebel was thrown from a window. Thus the dynasty of Omri came to an end. This scene closes the cycle of stories about Elijah and Ahab. The prophet foretold the fall of the dynasty, and the events in Jezreel show how severely the violation of an ordinary man's rights was judged.

Jezreel lies on the eastern edge of the Jezreel Valley, about 20 km from Megiddo, on a small rise overlooking a wide, fertile plain. The valley is the most fertile region of Israel: it runs from Carmel to the Jordan for about 40 km. Military and trade roads crossed here, so a ruler living in Jezreel could see an approaching army in advance. From the tower Jehu could be seen approaching from Ramoth Gilead. The Jezreel Valley appears in the Bible many times, from the days of Gideon to Josiah, and always as a place where the fate of the land is weighed.

FACTS

Length of the Jezreel Valley approx. 40 km; distance to Megiddo approx. 20 km.

Questions for Reflection

1. Why did David choose Jerusalem as his capital rather than Hebron, and what did that say about his way of ruling?

2. How did the location of Megiddo, Hazor, and Gezer help Solomon control trade and the security of the kingdom?

3. What does the story of Elijah on Mount Carmel say about the relationship between faith, power, and the people's trust in their leaders?